Kai Zhu

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Assistant Professor · Bocconi University · Milan, Italy

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Academic Positions

2022 – Present Assistant Professor, **Bocconi University**

2021 – 2022 Assistant Professor, **McGill University**

Education

2021 Ph.D. in Information Systems, **Boston University**

2015 M.A. in Economics, **Indiana University**

2013 B.A. in Economics, **Peking University**

2011 B.S. in Computer Science, **Beijing Language and Culture University**

Research Interests

Digital Platforms · Economics of Digitization · Artificial Intelligence · Computational Social Science

Research

Publications

The AI Democratization Paradox: Evidence from Decentralized Knowledge Communities

Management Science (2026)

with Dylan Walker (Chapman U)

Paper · Slides · Interactive App · AI Overview

Monetizing Platforms: An Empirical Analysis of Supply and Demand Responses to Entry Costs in Two-sided Markets

Management Science (2025)

with Qiaoni Shi (Bocconi) and Shrabastee Banerjee (Tilburg)

Paper · Slides · AI Poster · AI Overview

Negative Peer Feedback and User Content Generation: Evidence from a Restaurant Review Platform

Production and Operations Management (2024)

with Warut Khern-Am-Nual (McGill U) and Yinan Yu (U of Oklahoma)

If a Tree Falls in the Forest: Presidential Press Conferences and Early Media Narratives about the COVID-19 Crisis

Journal of Quantitative Description (2022)

with Masha Krupenkin (Boston College), Dylan Walker (Chapman U), David Rothschild (Microsoft)

Content Growth and Attention Contagion in Information Networks: Addressing Information Poverty on Wikipedia

Information Systems Research (2020)

with Dylan Walker (Chapman U) and Lev Muchnik (Hebrew U)

Working Papers

AI Search as an Information Intermediary: Clickstream Evidence on Web Traffic
with Qiaoni Shi (Bocconi) and Kai Gu (Bocconi)
Paper

Selective Participation in the AI Data Commons
Conditionally Accepted at ***Marketing Science***
Paper · Slides · Interactive App · AI Overview

Monetizing the Long Tail through Direct Audience Support: Platform Design and Creator Responses
Revise and Resubmit at ***Marketing Science***
with Xin Zhou (Bocconi)
Paper · Slides · AI Poster · AI Overview

Quantifying Consumer-Product Fit: A Representation Learning Approach
Revise and Resubmit at ***Journal of Marketing Research***
with Qiaoni Shi (Bocconi) and Christian Hotz-Behofsits (WU Vienna)
Paper · Slides · AI Poster · AI Overview

Work in Progress (Selected)

Can Technology Overcome Small Markets? Machine Translation and Access to Knowledge across Languages
with Joel Waldfogel (U of Minnesota) and Luis Aguiar (U of Zurich)

Manufacturing Excludability: The Emergence of Markets for AI Data Access

Awards & Grants

Award

Wikimedia Foundation Research Award of the Year, 2021

Grants

Italy Ministry of University and Research Fund (PRIN), 2023–2026
Role: Principal Investigator — €227,708

Canada SSHRC Insight Grant, 2022–2023
Role: Principal Investigator — CAD $79,749

Wikimedia Research & Technology Fund, 2022–2023
Role: Principal Investigator — USD $45,840

Teaching

AI Tools for Business Analysis

Agentic AI for Data-driven Insights

Academic Service

Program Committee

- Workshop on Platform Analytics, 2024/2025/2026
- Workshop on Information Technology and Systems, 2023/2024/2025
- Wiki Workshop, 2023/2024/2025/2026
- Conference for Information Systems and Technology, 2021

Associate Editor

- International Conference on Information Systems, 2023/2024/2025
- Pacific Asia Conference on Information Systems, 2024

Ad Hoc Reviewer

- Management Science
- MIS Quarterly
- Information Systems Research
- Production and Operations Management
- Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science
- Nature Communications

Presentations & Invited Talks

Can Technology Overcome Small Markets? Machine Translation and Access to Knowledge across Languages

Nova School of Business and Economics 2026

Selective Participation in the AI Data Commons

Digital Economy Workshop 2026

The AI Democratization Paradox: Evidence from Decentralized Knowledge Platforms

Wiki Workshop 2022 · McGill University 2022 · Statistical Challenges in E-commerce Research 2022 · Wikimedia Foundation 2022 · WITS 2022 · Statistical Challenges in E-commerce Research 2023 · Wikimania 2023 · WISE 2023 · Digital Economy Workshop 2024 · Munich Summer Institute 2024 · Bocconi Marketing Research Camp 2024 · Mapping and Governing the Online World 2024 · Wikimedia Research Showcase 2024 · WU Vienna 2024 · HEC Lausanne 2024 · UK Digital Economics Workshop 2025 · Conference on AI and ML 2025 · WISE 2025 · National University of Singapore 2026

Monetizing Platforms: An Empirical Analysis of Supply and Demand Responses to Entry Costs in Two-sided Markets

CODE 2021* · Bocconi University 2022 · Singapore Management University 2022* · Indian Institute of Management 2022* · EMAC 2022* · Customer Journey in a Digital World 2022* · Statistical Challenges in E-commerce Research 2022 · WISE 2022* · HICSS 2023 · London Business School 2023* · University College London 2023* · Imperial College London 2023* · Workshop on Platform Analytics 2024* · Creator Economy Retreat 2025*

Content Growth and Attention Contagion in Information Networks: Addressing Information Poverty on Wikipedia

WWW 2017 · CODE 2017 · WISE 2017 · Statistical Challenges in E-commerce Research 2018 · Harvard Business School 2018 · WEBEIS 2019 · Wiki Workshop 2020 · Microsoft Research NYC 2020 · McGill University 2020 · Wikimedia Research Showcase 2021

Negative Peer Feedback and User Content Generation: Evidence from a Restaurant Review Platform

AMCIS 2021 · Statistical Challenges in E-commerce Research 2021 · CIST 2021*

If a Tree Falls in the Forest: COVID-19, Media Choices, and Presidential Agenda Setting

ICWSM 2020* · PaCSS 2020* · BU Institute for Health System Innovation & Policy 2020

How Media Ownership Impacts Information Skews: A Study of Televised News Using Massive-Scale Text Transcripts

PaCSS 2018 · Statistical Challenges in E-commerce Research 2019 · WISE 2019 · Boston University 2020 · Microsoft Research NYC 2020

* presented by a coauthor